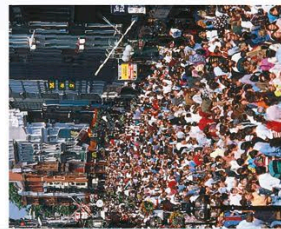




The British Isles

FOR SUCH A SMALL GROUP OF ISLANDS, the British Isles has a very rich history. This is evident from its legacy of ancient ruins, medieval castles, dramatic cathedrals, and grand country houses. Once a leading industrial and colonial power, British monarchs ruled an empire that circled the globe. As a result, English is still widely spoken around the world. Today, many traditional industries, such as shipbuilding, mining, and engineering, have declined, and the emphasis is now on banking and insurance, as well as pharmaceuticals. The British Isles consists of two countries: the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland (the UK), and the Republic of Ireland.

Wales has more than 200 castles.



IRELAND
Tourists visit Ireland, attracted by its unspoiled countryside and lively cities, such as Dublin (left). Once part of Britain, Ireland gained independence in 1922. Its economy, the fastest-growing in Europe just before the global banking crisis of 2008, has since seen good recovery.

HORSE BREEDING

Lush pastures and a mild climate have encouraged the breeding of thoroughbred racehorses in Ireland. Stud farms here raise some of the best racehorses in the world.



Irish horse and rider on a training run



SCOTLAND

Scotland and England united as a single country in 1707. Today, however, Scotland is a self-governing part of the UK, with its own parliament and distinct legal and educational systems. Edinburgh, above, is a popular city with a magnificent castle. Each summer, the city hosts an international arts festival.



NORTH SEA ENERGY

Beneath the shallow seas around Britain, there are supplies of oil and natural gas. Oil rigs raise oil and gas to the surface, where it is pumped by pipeline to be refined on the mainland. Production has declined and supplies are now running low, but more distant reserves still wait to be exploited. However, few businesses are willing to take on further costly exploration.



MONEY MATTERS

The City of London is the UK's financial center. Before the banking crash of 2008, more than 500 banks had offices there. Lloyd's Insurance Building (right) is one of the city's most distinctive skyscrapers. Built of steel and glass, its elevators are outside.

